

ALPHABET HANDS

Silence. A planet floating in water and encased in plastic on the end of a key chain, rolls like a broken compass playing tug of war against a tag of paper with blue ink illustrations of hands, corresponding letters and a simple statement expressing the gratitude donations to the deaf. Over and around the rim of the box, the instructions applaud through the fall wind. Unaware of the cheering is a young man stretching the morning out of his face. He squeezes his eyelids together tightly. Darkness. His pen points out of the heavy fold of his sock hat toward the expectations of a double-decker bus. The pen looks forward at the morning lit, swollen, empty London Street. He closes his eyes: darkness. He opens his eyes: street. He closes his eyes: long darkness. He opens his eyes: bus.

The doors vibrate open. A careful and deliberate walk up the stairs to plexy- glass holes to speak to the bus driver. He does not move his lips. With one of the hands that holds the box of planet key chains and the relaxed tags of instructions, he deposits the fare into the dish. The bus driver takes the money and does not move his lips. The man moves his mouth close to the holes, steams the glass, and wipes with haste and embarrassment. He looks for a seat close to the door. There are three passengers spread unevenly on one side of the bus. He sits and looks back at the bus driver's newly cleaned window. Darkness.

A brown-bag clothed woman stands, pays and moves passed the man. A young Indian girl follows behind smiling. They stare at each other as she passes.

The man looks out the windows across from him. A hand clamps over the handrail next to his eye. Pink fingernails. A female hand. A white, stocking covered knee then a band of bruised skin between a foe school girl's skirt and the top of her knee-highs. A slightly scuffed green purse swings in and out of view. A multi-colored high heel shoe. A sheer coat with lace floats straight into the bus. Beneath is a half-naked emaciated girl in a black bra. She digs through her purse quickly with money already in her hand. Her black hair obscures her face while she fingers the money and places it in the dish, and walks down the aisle between the seats. She does not look at the man holding the box. She reels back laughing. Her fingers absent and frantic make a plus sign in the air. The driver peers back into the bus and opens his mouth wide and closes it. She slaps her leg with her fist. The man looks over her shoulder at the number of people waiting to board the bus. The driver waves a confused hand in a go and stay fashion until his resolved thumb appears and points to the back of the bus. She walks backwards to a seat as far as her uneasy facial expressions will allow. Conscious of this, she sits. The new passengers resume boarding and confirm seats for themselves. They pass the young lady that is with hand up open and moving her lips to a selection of commuters. They all fall back when the bus moves forward. The driver leans his face toward the change hole. He opens his mouth half as wide twice as many times. She does not move. The length of the bus driver's arm points up. He holds up one finger and wipes the air repetitively with his open hand then motions up the road. She slumps slightly in her seat looking down. She pulls her pleated skirt high enough to see her belly. She uses

a fingernail to remove a speck of dirt from her naked pubic bone. She lowers her skirt, pulls out the nonexistent wrinkles from the sleeves of the transparent coat, and stands. The man with the box is watching and confused. The woman steps back four steps, turns to the front of the bus, puts her feet shoulder width apart, drops hands down, gives an exaggerated movement to her hips while she steps in time to an inaudible song. She is not moving her lips. Walking with one arm raised, she looks sharply to the left and the right. Her eyes are vacant to her surroundings. She stands in front of the bus driver, opens the taffeta coat with the feather boa outlining, turns her head facing down the evenly filled seats, and rotates the upper and lower half of her body in opposite directions. The man releases one side of the box, lays down to get into his pockets, and finds money. The woman putting her vagina next to the coin slot goes unnoticed except by the man, who with box in hand places a coin in the tin and shocks the now aware bus driver. He fogs the glass with his breathy mouthing. He does not wipe, pulls back to his place, lifts the box onto his lap, settles and straightens. Falling with his momentum she slumps next to him. The bus stops, transforming pedestrians to passengers. While she is looking at the box and him, he looks out the front to the stop. She chops the air in front of his vision. The door closes. The bus goes forward.

He suddenly hands her a key chain from the box. The tag and planet lay balanced over his finger that points at her. Relaxing her neck on the fiber glass seat she pulls it off. He contracts. She straightens with a pinch the slightly unreadable numbers, letters and alphabet of hands. The bus bounces to a stop

then continues. She turns her head away and hands it back to him. He takes the key chain faster than she expects and smiles.

A little girl in an adult's down coat appears from behind the trousers of a passenger to scare the man with the box. They sign together then take turns. She moves her hands. He moves his hands. They both look at the girl and pause. She looks away like a snooping landlord that has been caught. The girl tugs harder on the man's sleeve. She opens her empty plastic grocery bag for him. He fills his hands from the box and lets go of the contents in her bag. The girl keeps an eye on the tired, half-naked woman. He grabs her chin and points it toward him. The girl's eyes mechanically turn back. He signs close to her eyes. He shoes her toward the back of the bus. She stops staring and steps individually toward the passengers dropping key chains next to them all. The man looks at the woman unworried and the woman looks at the little girl with desperate ignorance. This continues until the girl's down coat brushes its way to the seat between the two's legs. They all look forward. Two planets disappear and are replaced with money. Pocket origami crumpled bills now occupy the seats. The little girl moves unfettered to the gathering of planets and payments. Her bag bulges once again. She goes to the side door. The bus stops. She waves. He waves. And she is gone.

The doors vibrate closed and continue en route. He takes a key chain from his box, tears the tag from the ring, lays it flat and pushes it toward her with his index finger. She accepts it reluctantly. She looks at it and lifts her hand to replicate the pictures on the paper. He stands, situates himself toward the center

of the bus, waits for it to stop and the doors to open. It begins to slow. The woman signs the letter L. The doors open moments before it completely stops. The young lady discards the flyer in the well of the seat next to her. A man in his sixties stands at the opening with a grocery sack. The young man fills his hands twice, emptying both into the old man's bag. They smile at each other. The door closes.